50TH ANNIVERSARY

WELFARE STATE 2005-2015



DATABASE NATION People getting enrolled for Aadhaar card in Pune, Dec. 2011

BHASKAR PAUL

A Shocking Divide
Aug. 14, 2006

"Clearly, our schools, colleges, governments and social systems have failed to foster an effective and inclusive environment that could have induced most Muslim families to educationally empower their children in the same way as others."



While plagued by leakages and uneven implementation, MGNREGA changed rural labour markets, raised wage floors and gave political voice to the poor.

The next major leap came with Aadhaar, launched in 2009. Conceived as a biometric identity platform, it sought to solve a persistent problem of Indian governance: the inability of the State to accurately identify beneficiaries. By assigning a unique identity linked to fingerprints and iris scans, Aadhaar promised to eliminate ghost beneficiaries and enable direct benefit transfers. Over time, Aadhaar became the backbone of India's digital welfare architecture, enabling subsidy reform, financial inclusion, and portability of benefits. At the same time, it raised profound questions about privacy, surveillance and State power that continue to animate constitutional debate.

WITH THE RTI ACT, ACCESS TO GOVT RECORDS WAS NO LONGER A PRIVILEGE MEDIATED BY POWER, BUT A STATUTORY RIGHT VESTED IN THE CITIZEN

The rights-based framework reached its most expansive expression with the National Food Security Act of 2013. By legally entitling nearly two-thirds of India's population to subsidised food grains, the state assumed responsibility for protecting citizens against hunger at a scale never attempted before. Critics questioned its fiscal sustainability and efficiency, but its political logic was unmistakable.

Yet, beneath this architecture of empowerment, older social fractures remained stubbornly intact. Caste hierarchies and minority deprivation continued to shape lived realities. The mid-2000s saw intense agitation over the extension of OBC reservations to higher education. The expansion of quotas produced new anxieties, new agitations and new fault lines without resolving the core problem of unequal access to quality education and employment. Similarly, due to the stark educational divide between Muslims and non-Muslims, a large section of Muslim youth risked being excluded from the educated workforce, with potentially explosive social consequences.

The paradox of the decade is therefore stark. Welfare laws expanded access, but they did not dismantle structural disadvantage rooted in history, discrimination and geography. ■